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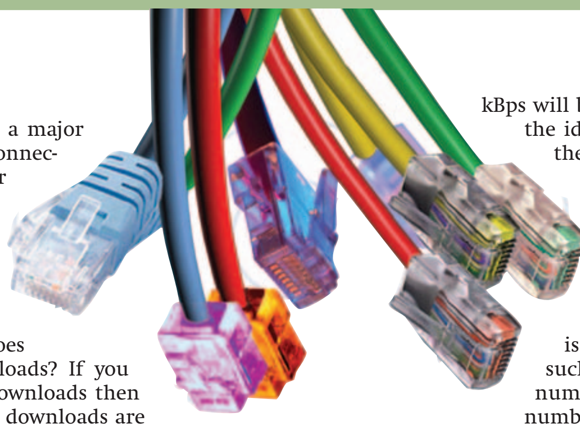


The right plan and connection

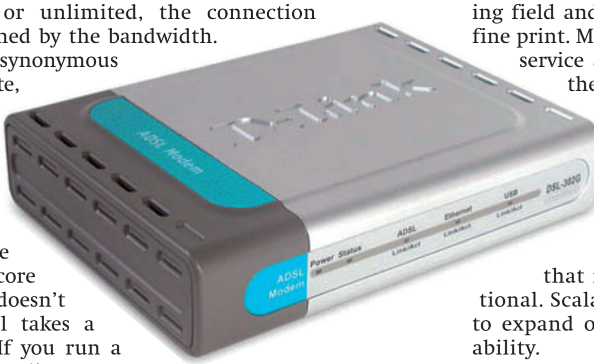
The nature of your business will play a major role in deciding your ideal internet connection. If you are using the internet for simple tasks such as emailing with less browsing, you will require a different plan compared to a graphics processing outfit working for an offshore client.

You should also look at the kind of traffic you are likely to produce. Does it consist more of uploads or downloads? If you find that your uploads are equal to downloads then you should go in for a 1:1 line. If your downloads are high and sending large files via FTP doesn't form part of your daily function then go in for a line that offers, for example, upstream rates of 256 kbps while the downstream rate is 1 Mbps.

When considering the type of connection, whether to prefer cable, DSL or WiMax, depends largely on the data plans and rates. ISPs have several data plans designed for businesses, which essentially offer combinations between speed, download limits and price. Typically, ISPs might charge users a flat fee per month or apply charges based on usage. Usage may be calculated by time spent browsing (per hour) or downloaded data. There are also plans where you find a combination of both. For example, the MTNL Tri-Band "Trib Business 7199" plan that offers 45 GB downloads for Rs. 7,199 and an additional 70 paise per MB for downloads beyond the 45 GB limit. There may be other plans where usage during the day is calculated by hours spent online while during the night, it shifts to a per-MB basis.

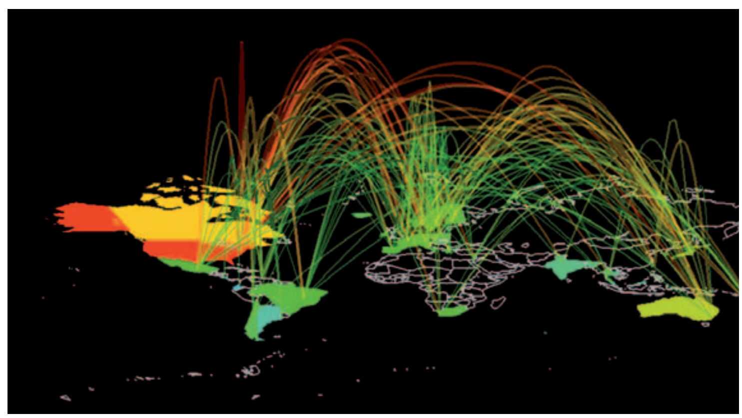
Broadly, plans are categorised into limited usage and unlimited plans. If the volume of your internet usage is high, then an unlimited plan is a good idea. Limited plans usually have a fixed component of charges that cover a certain allowable download limit, say 500 MB. Beyond that limit, you will be charged a certain amount per MB or GB of downloaded data.

Whether limited or unlimited, the connection speed of a plan is defined by the bandwidth. Bandwidth is almost synonymous with data transfer rate, and therefore, synonymous with speed. Choosing the bandwidth depends on the criticality of speed to your business. If your internet usage is not part of your core business function, it doesn't matter much if email takes a little longer to open. If you run a graphics solutions or media company, it's likely you will need to send heavy files and browse rich content, so speed is important.



So how do you calculate your bandwidth requirement? Say your company is into wholesale exports, and much of your employees' time is spent sending mails and viewing prices of commodities. High speed is not very critical, and you have about 30 machines that need access to the internet. To be able to browse at decent speed, you need to have an effective speed of 15 kBps for each computer. So, at any given point of time, your connection's bandwidth should be able to support 450 kBps (450 x 8 = 3,600 kbps). Also, this does not mean that a constant stream of 450 kBps will be consumed at all times, considering the idle time and intermittent requests on the connection. Therefore, a bandwidth of 2 Mbps should suffice for this scenario.

You may also be able to find online resources such as You Telecom's plan calculator. It generates an estimate of your bandwidth and data transfer requirement. This is done by entering estimates of usage such as number of hours spent online, number of programs downloaded, and number of emails likely to be sent.



Factors while choosing an ISP

You have several players such as Bharti Airtel, MTNL, BSNL, Reliance Communications, Tata Indicom and even local cable operators that offer internet services. Where there is a level playing field and all tariffs / plan details are the same, look at the fine print. Most ISPs try to hide complicated clauses within their service agreements which basically help them go back on their promised services.

Look at things such as sharing ratio. Sharing ratio signifies how many users are going to be serviced by the same line to which you are subscribing. A sharing ratio of 1:1 means that you are the only subscriber on that line. Up time is also another important factor while choosing an ISP and is a measure of reliability that is indicative of the total time the service is functional. Scalability is also something to look at. If you're likely to expand operations, your current ISP should support scalability.

Customer service is another factor to consider. Is the ISP quick to respond to complaints? Most of this information can be gathered by consulting your friends and other users around. Since quality of service is also different in different geographies, it's advisable to find out through other offices in your area, about their subscribed ISP.

Value added services can also be a differentiator. Most ISPs bundle benefits such as SMTP servers, web space, and email ids. It's important to figure out if any of these services are relevant to your organisation and whether to choose a particular ISP for them. ■

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